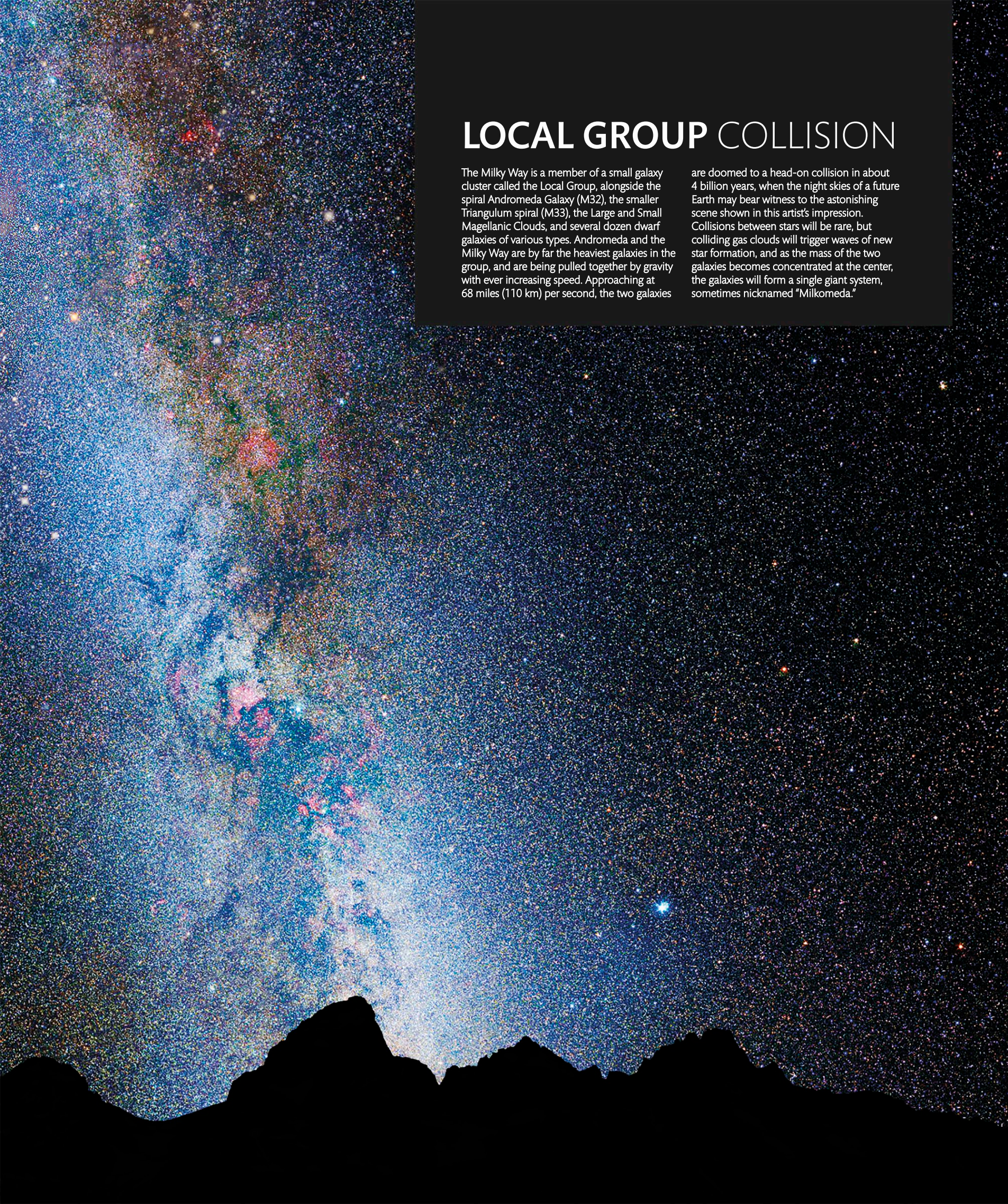




LOCAL GROUP COLLISION

The Milky Way is a member of a small galaxy cluster called the Local Group, alongside the spiral Andromeda Galaxy (M32), the smaller Triangulum spiral (M33), the Large and Small Magellanic Clouds, and several dozen dwarf galaxies of various types. Andromeda and the Milky Way are by far the heaviest galaxies in the group, and are being pulled together by gravity with ever increasing speed. Approaching at 68 miles (110 km) per second, the two galaxies

are doomed to a head-on collision in about 4 billion years, when the night skies of a future Earth may bear witness to the astonishing scene shown in this artist's impression. Collisions between stars will be rare, but colliding gas clouds will trigger waves of new star formation, and as the mass of the two galaxies becomes concentrated at the center, the galaxies will form a single giant system, sometimes nicknamed "Milkomeda."